

UNDERSTANDING FAMILY HISTORY

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Implement a plan for recovery from addiction that reduces the impact of ACOA traits on sobriety.
2. Reduce the frequency of behaviors exclusively designed to please others.
3. Begin to choose partners and friends who are responsible, respectful, and reliable.
4. Help friends and family understand how they can help by avoiding codependent behaviors.
5. Learn new ways to interact with the family in adult life.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE ACOA TRAITS

- Am I Teaching My Children Addictive Patterns?
- Building My Support Network
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Corresponding with My Childhood Self
- Forming Stable Relationships
- How Far Have I Come?
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Codependent Behaviors
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- Using My Support Network
- What Did I Want to Be When I Grew Up?
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What's Happening in My Early Recovery?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Childhood Trauma
- Family Conflicts
- Parent-Child Relational Problems

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Understanding Family History” activity may be used effectively with clients experiencing shame, confusion, or anxiety as a result of seeing themselves repeat negative behaviors seen in childhood caretakers. It may be useful in couples therapy, since many ACOA individuals form relationships with partners with similar backgrounds. For clients struggling with acceptance and forgiveness of their parents or of themselves, this activity may help in understanding the roles of addiction and powerlessness in distorting values and behaviors. It may also be useful for clients in recovery who have parenting issues to understand the roots of their children’s behaviors.

UNDERSTANDING FAMILY HISTORY

It's important to understand the role that family history plays in the development of addictive behaviors, both for your own recovery and to improve things within your family. Biological, psychological, and social factors combine in different ways for different people to influence the development of these patterns. This exercise looks at how family history and patterns affect us.

1. As a child, whom did you see drinking, using drugs, gambling, eating compulsively, or practicing other addictive behaviors in your family? _____ How old were you when you first understood what they were doing? _____ What effects did this have on you?

2. What did you learn about drinking, drug use, and/or other addictions from your family?

3. What problems, if any, did your family have as a result of these behaviors (for example, violence, divorce, financial problems, dangerous or illegal activities, or other worries)?

4. Please describe the typical atmosphere or mood in your family when someone was drinking, using drugs, gambling, or engaging in any other addictive pattern:

5. Families with addictive patterns often interact in some common ways. For each of the following patterns that you have experienced, give an example from your childhood and an example of how you can make positive changes now.
 - a. *Dishonesty/denial*
 - (1) Childhood example: _____

 - (2) Working toward positive change: _____

b. *Breaking promises*

(1) Childhood example: _____

(2) Working toward positive change: _____

c. *Isolating/withdrawing*

(1) Childhood example: _____

(2) Working toward positive change: _____

d. *Emotional/physical/sexual abuse and neglect*

(1) Childhood example: _____

(2) Working toward positive change: _____

e. *Influencing others to act in self-destructive ways*

(1) Childhood example: _____

(2) Working toward positive change: _____

f. *Mixed-up roles and responsibilities (such as children taking caring of adults, or people blaming others for their own actions)*

(1) Childhood example: _____

(2) Working toward positive change: _____

6. What good relationship patterns from your childhood do you want to continue and to pass on?

7. How does your family of origin still affect your alcohol and/or other drug use, other addictive behaviors, ineffective or self-harming behavior, or recovery efforts?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.